

Swing, Soul & Samba:

A Tribute to Washington DC

Historical liner notes by Ken Avis



KEN AVIS

Washington DC has always pulsed to a musical heartbeat. Wave after wave of people have made the city their home, bringing with them their music, creating and innovating across every genre you can imagine. From jazz to bluegrass, country to soul, an illustrious musical history.

Recorded live and accompanied by the Bohemian Caverns Jazz Orchestra, Ayo's love letter to the people and the music of DC Swing, Soul & Samba celebrates one corner of DC's music history. Her album explores the jazz flavors created by some of our brightest musical talents, some of whom have become forgotten over the generations; all of whom deserve to be remembered.

Duke Ellington

Born in 1899, Edward Kennedy Ellington grew up right by “Black Broadway”, U St. Ellington would become world renowned as a composer, bandleader and an global ambassador for the African American people. DC’s most famous musical son.

Elegant in speech and style and referred to as “America’s Beethoven” in recognition of his more than five hundred compositions, Ellington encompassed jazz and went “beyond category” into other musical forms.

Initially a reluctant piano student who preferred to play baseball, Ellington caught the bug after hearing ragtime pianists playing along U Street in places like Frank Holidays Pool Hall, next door to the Howard Theater. He formed his first small band as a teenager, playing in and around DC and out into the neighboring small towns of Virginia and Maryland, before striking out for the New York City.

Duke Ellington

It was a case of right time, right place, and massive talent. After some initial false starts his career exploded when he was engaged at New York's Cotton Club from 1927-1932, a club featuring Black performers for a whites-only audience. Ellington's Cotton Club performances were broadcast on the radio, a new invention of the time, making him a household name nationally.

Ellington continued to develop his craft and his career, building an impressive roster of musicians and spearheading the big-band era of the jazz age and into the 1930's. He was a regular visitor to DC performing at major venues like the Howard Theater. As movies came along, he appeared in film, and toured world-wide. For a period he even had his name on the building which now houses the 9:30 Club on 9th Street DC. His name can be found all around DC - The Duke Ellington School of Music, Duke Ellington Bridge and in the murals and statues celebrating the cities pride for the man and his music.

Ayo's "Come Sunday" is an Ellington composition recorded with gospel vocalist Mahalia Jackson in 1958, part of his "sacred jazz" suite Black, Brown and Beige performed at Carnegie Hall on January 23, 1943.

Blanche Calloway

Why there has never been a movie of Blanche Calloway's life is a mystery! Raised alongside her younger brother Cab Calloway in Baltimore, Blanche performed in Broadway's first Black musical theater show "Shuffle Along" written by Baltimore's Eubie Blake, a show which launched other emerging stars Josephine Baker and Paul Robeson. She soon went on to success as a recording artists singing with Louis Armstrong in the 1920's. Hi Di Hi was recorded by Blanche Calloway and Her Joy Boys in 1931.

Soon she was running her own touring big-band, Blanche Calloway & Her Joy Boys, reputed to be the first woman ever to lead an all-male jazz big band. The Joy Boys ranked in the Top 10 US bands of 1933. Her success came to an end when she was arrested and jailed in Mississippi for using a whites-only bathroom. When she got out the band had absconded with the vehicles, money and instruments, so Blanche returned to New York and formed an all-women big band.

Blanche Calloway

After WWII she returned to manage the legendary Bohemian Caverns on thriving U Street, DC's "Black Broadway". It was there that she met, befriended and hired vocalist Ruth Brown, launching her career as Atlantic Records first successful recording star, after inviting Atlantic Records founder and DC resident Ahmet Ertegun, the son of the Turkish Ambassador.

Blanche went on to be a DJ and then to run a Florida radio franchise, before returning to Baltimore to marry her high-school sweetheart, and go on to build a Black cosmetics company. Brother Cab Calloway, incidentally, got his break in show business through Blanche and his performance style echoed many of her trademark moves.

What a woman!

Ruth Brown

Remember Ruth Brown....how did she meet Blanche Calloway? Good question! Her first show in DC was performing as a teenage vocalist with a touring band at the Howard Theater. Taking exception to something she had done the bandleader fired the teenager, putting her off the bus and leaving her in the alleyway besides the Theater. A kindly patron from Frank Holidays Pool Hall, next door found her and introduced her to Blanche Calloway who gave her a room for the night and offered her a singing gig in the club. The rest, as they say, is history.

Calloway took Ruth under her wing and arranged her Atlantic Records contract. Ruth had 16 hits on the new record label between 1949-55. People referred to Atlantic as “The Label Ruth Brown Built”! During that time her pianist was a young Ray Charles who went on to his own success with Atlantic. One of her biggest hit’s on the Rhythm and Blues chart was “Mama, He Treat Your Daughter Mean”. She was also singing jazz, appearing with such artists as Miles Davis in the 1950’s.

Ruth Brown

Despite her contribution to building Atlantic Records success, Ruth didn't receive the royalties due to her and later in her career led a successful artist's revolt to reclaim their missing payments and in the process established a not-for-profit to support retired musicians.

After a break to raise her family in the 1960's Ruth Brown re-invented herself, returning to the public as a blues singer, first in the successful "Women Of The Blues" show on Broadway. As a touring and recording artist, she went on through the '90's to earn Grammy nominations, induction to the Rock & Roll Hall of Fame, and toured with musicians like BB King and Bonnie Raitt, as well as hosting her own NPR radio program.

Once again, what a woman!

Charlie Byrd

Charlie Byrd, a guitarist from deepest Virginia, brought Brazilian bossa-nova to the mainstream in the 1960's with his Jazz Samba album, recorded in the same church as Ayo's album. Bossa nova was so little known at the time, that the album notes just described it as the "traditional samba of Brazil, mixed with American jazz".

Charlie and his trio came across the music on a US State Department sponsored tour of Latin America, where they were to serve as cultural ambassadors. They came back with more than they bargained for after encountering the irresistible new sound in Brazil. The new sound started to creep into their weekly shows at DC's jazz clubs, and found an audience with the cities international residents. Within a short time the decision was made to record an album of the new material and All Souls Unitarian church was chosen as the venue. Jazz legend Stan Getz was drafted-in to play sax and all was set.

Ayo recorded this album with the Bohemian Caverns Jazz Orchestra at All Souls Church in 2022 to honor the 60th anniversary of jazz samba.

Charlie Byrd

One cold morning Getz arrived at National Airport and made his way to the church where Charlie and his band were gathered. An unusual line up of two drummers, two bass players Charlie's regular bassist Keeter Betts and his younger brother, Joe Byrd. The now familiar sound was deemed so unusual that it needed extra hands! Within three hours the album was recorded, with three microphones, to a reel-to-reel tape recorder in the corridor. The engineer edited the tapes, handed over the master and everyone left, with no high expectations of what might happen next.

What did happen next was the album became a sensation and launched a global bossa nova craze. The first single, interpreted on Ayo's album was Desifando. In the UK the Beatles wrote a few bossa nova songs for their next album, while in the US there was a flood of bossa nova albums by Ella Fitzgerald, Frank Sinatra and everyone else....even Elvis Presley would "Blame It On The Bossa Nova"!

Charlie Byrd

The mainstreaming of the style launched the careers of the original Brazilian composer like Antonio Carlos Jobim, Joao Gilberto and Sergio Mendez who performed with the Charlie Byrd Trio at Carnegie Hall and the Lisner Auditorium in 1962.

Charlie went on to tour the world for the rest of his career, releasing over 100 albums of jazz, blues, and classical guitar music, while staying close to home to sail his boat “I’m Hip” from Annapolis, MD. He was knighted in Brazil for his services to Brazilian culture. Not bad for a hip dude from DC via Chuckatuck Virginia. If you take a trip to hear music at the Mainstream in Rock Hall you can find a mini-museum dedicated to Charlie Byrd in the back room bar of one of his favorite local venues. Amazing to think that without Charlie Byrd’s involvement, bossa nova might have never made the journey outside of Brazil!